A Celebration of DANCE

The upcoming Indian Dance Festival at Mamallapuram is a month-long spectacle that promises an entrancing display of Indian classical and folk dance forms

Every winter, aficionados of Indian dance gather at the enchanting Shore Temple complex in Mamallapuram to witness some of the greatest exponents of Indian classical and folk dance forms, showcasing their fine craft in an array of splendid performances. The Indian Dance Festival is a grand, month-long extravaganza which honours the spirit of Indian dance.

Organised by the Department of Tourism, Government of Tamil Nadu, the Indian Dance Festival is a celebration of the diverse regional cultures of India and their expression in the form of dance. The festival features traditional folk art forms such as Mayilattam, Karagam, Kavadi, Thappattam and Oyilattam, as well as classical dance forms such as Bharatanatyam, Kuchipudi and Kathak. Leading classical dance performers from across India gather to perform at the premier event. The carefully curated performances serve as the perfect showcase of 'unity in diversity' and leave the audience spellbound year after year. The themes of the performances are based on mythological stories and the vibrant dance forms breathe life into the narratives. The magical setting of the Shore Temple too plays its part in elevating the performances.



Mamallapuram, renowned for its rich heritage, is the ideal setting for this vibrant festival, where classical dance forms come alive against a mesmerising backdrop, entrancing the spectators with rhythmic movements and traditional artistry. While festival attendees are regaled with traditional folk art performances and classical dances from various regions of India in the evenings, during the day they are free to explore the stunning UNESCO-inscribed World Heritage Monuments of Mamallapuram. The Pallava-era monuments, seemingly frozen in time, are a sight to behold.

You can begin your tour with the Pancha Rathas, fine examples of Indian monolithic rock-cut architecture. Next on your itinerary should be Arjuna's Penance. Also known as Descent of the Ganges, it is one of the largest open-air rock reliefs in the world and depicts the tale of the descent of the river Ganges onto earth from heaven.

Your next stop should be the Panchapandava Cave Temple. Do note its beautiful verandah columns featuring lion bases. After this, head to the marvel that is Krishna's Butterball, a gigantic balancing rock that even the Pallava king Narasimhavarman (630-668 CE) couldn't move. To make it a full-day of sightseeing, explore the Varaha Cave Temple, Trimurti Cave and Mahishasuramardini Cave as well. The Varaha Cave Temple, situated in a hilltop village, features a prominent sculpture of Vishnu in his Varaha (boar) incarnation.

Arguably the most spectacular monument in Mamallapuram is the Shore Temple, the resplendent venue of the dance festival. It stands as a timeless marvel along the Bay of Bengal. Carved from granite, the architectural masterpiece features intricately detailed sculptures and reliefs, offering a captivating glimpse into ancient Pallava art and culture. As the waves gently lap against the shore, visitors are transported to a bygone era.

It's not just heritage that draws visitors to Mamallapuram. The colonial-era Lighthouse, the Indian Seashell Museum and Sculpture Museum are other interesting attractions here. If you're a wildlife enthusiast, don't miss the Crocodile Bank. Souvenir hunters will find a range of wood and stone artifacts to choose from, especially statues carved in granite and soapstone, as well as decorative items made of seashells. While here, tuck into some delectable seafood besides popular staples like dosa, idli and vada.

By evening, it is time to immerse yourself in the magic of dance. The Indian Dance Festival at Mamallapuram is a display of India's colourful folk traditions and charismatic dances on a grand scale—and the splendid setting and electrifying performances make it a must visit.





